

(4.2) release packaged on a CD that came with a book. This book was very comprehensive and it enabled me to learn Perl, awk, Emacs, Apache, Samba and LaTeX.

A feeling of great excitement gripped me as I had finally found an operating system with the boundless scope to explore, learn and build new things. I can't imagine what I would have done without this freedom to use, study and learn.

Q Any individuals or platforms that played a significant role in strengthening your belief and connection with FOSS?

Soon after I started using GNU/Linux, I discovered the GNU Manifesto. The politics of the software offered a completely different perspective on how to do computing. So, in that sense, reading essays by RMS (Richard Matthew Stallman) was the first 'non-technical' influence that I had. At the same time, I also read Eric Raymond's 'Cathedral and the Bazaar' essay and that had an influence on me as well.

I was a part of the LiveWire! BBS before we got Internet in '95. So, I learnt my email etiquette, concepts of online communication, collaboration and the spirit of healthy online discussions on various BBS, BharatNet and FidoNet forums. Most of the people who were on the BBSs at that time went on to be very active in the free software community too.

Also, I was a part of a community called the Microcomputer User's Club (MUC). It was an informal community of programmers and computer users who would meet over weekends, swap floppies of software, give technical talks and share knowledge with each other. Many of these people also had a deep interest in electronics and the DIY culture with respect to computers. And I believe, it is from them that I acquired the DIY attitude, which I later channelised into FOSS (and hardware work) once I got started with it.

After I started DeepRoot, there were several other people, events and

'platforms' that played an important role in reinforcing my personal belief in free software. This includes so many people in the free software community (students and team members who have worked with us and our community of users and customers) who have supported us by giving us their business and patronage.

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Q So has FOSS played a pivotal role in your professional life in any way? Do share the details.

My professional life has only been about free software. While I was still a student, I used to manage servers for a friend, who later played a critical role in mentoring and helping me get started with DeepRoot. He ran a fairly large email and Web hosting company (around 1999/2000) and I also worked for some ISPs. All these servers were powered by GNU/Linux and free software. That is how I decided to work full time to start a company that would build products and provide such solutions.

All my 'professional' earnings have been out of FOSS. I began to understand the ideology of software freedom while running the business, and that helped me interpret and appreciate the philosophy and not just the technology. Understanding FOSS later enabled me to interact with all sorts of people professionally.

It has provided me the opportunities to do such a wide variety of things. It has enabled me to solve problems for a very large number of diverse organisations. And it has also helped me

to cultivate, and then hone my skills as a 'hacker'.

Today, if we have enabled others to learn about free software in so many ways, it is all because we have had the opportunity to learn about those things from others. Otherwise, it would have been impossible to build the sort of solutions we have built over the past 18 years.

Q Has FOSS also affected any aspects of your personal life?

FOSS has had a great impact on me personally as well. For me, free software is not just a professional thing to do... it's a way of life. The free software movement has taught me important lessons on reciprocity, fairness, sharing-alike, on respecting others, on cultivating empathy and, most importantly, on the value and essence of personal freedom.

I have learnt the value of having a strong (and recognisable) value system and standing by it — especially in the face of resistance, inconvenience and discouragement.

Adopting free software as a way of life has also made it possible for me to understand and appreciate other social movements and learn from them as well.

Free software has enabled me to build a personal ethic of sharing knowledge. Throughout school and then college, we are not really taught to share knowledge — not formally at least.

Q How do you view the current status of FOSS? Has it evolved as per your expectations?

The current status of FOSS is much below my expectations. I feel this is primarily because of two factors: (a) we routinely choose convenience over freedom or control in technology, and (b) we are not always mindful about the choices we are making, and whether they are consistent with whatever we want to be optimising for in our lives.

Today, we don't often see the dangers of proprietary software and